

VISUAL GUIDE · DR CLAIRE MORAN · THE QUALITATIVE RESEARCH INSTITUTE

Which type of thematic analysis is right for your study?

A clear, visual framework for choosing the approach that matches your analytic aim, philosophical position, and quality criteria.



Three approaches, each designed for a different analytic purpose

CODING RELIABILITY TA

Consistency across coders

ANALYTIC AIM

Systematically categorise responses with demonstrable consistency

THEME DEFINITION

A category of shared content that can be reliably identified

RESEARCHER ROLE

Neutral classifier applying consistent rules across data

PRIMARY QUALITY MARKER

Inter-rater reliability

CODEBOOK / CODING FRAME TA

Shared framework, auditable decisions

ANALYTIC AIM

Map patterned responses using a shared, evolving codebook

THEME DEFINITION

A patterned response that can be identified and verified by others

RESEARCHER ROLE

Interpretive mapper working within an auditable framework

PRIMARY QUALITY MARKER

Transparency and traceable decisions

REFLEXIVE TA

Patterns of shared meaning

ANALYTIC AIM

Interpret the meaning people make of their lived experiences

THEME DEFINITION

A pattern of shared meaning the researcher actively constructs

RESEARCHER ROLE

Reflexive co-constructor — subjectivity is a resource, not a problem

PRIMARY QUALITY MARKER

Reflexivity and interpretive depth

CR — PHILOSOPHICAL POSITION

Post-positivist. Reality is knowable; researcher bias is a threat to be managed. Reliability and replicability matter.

CF — PHILOSOPHICAL POSITION

Constructivist-pragmatist. Knowledge is co-constructed but must be traceable and auditable for applied contexts.

RTA — PHILOSOPHICAL POSITION

Constructivist-interpretivist. Meaning is co-constructed. Researcher subjectivity is acknowledged, explored, and used.

CR — THE KEY QUESTION

"Can we categorise these responses consistently across multiple coders?"

CF — THE KEY QUESTION

"Can we map these patterns in a way others can follow and verify?"

RTA — THE KEY QUESTION

"What meanings are these people making, and what can I say about why?"

How the three approaches differ across five key dimensions

DIMENSION	Coding Reliability TA	Codebook / Coding Frame TA	Reflexive TA
ANALYTIC AIM	Categorise reliably Systematically identify and group content with consistency across coders	Map patterns transparently Identify and document patterns using a shared, evolving framework	Interpret meaning Construct rich interpretive accounts of how people make sense of experience
THEME DEFINITION	A reliable category Identified by applying rules that multiple coders can follow consistently	A mapped pattern Documented in a codebook and verifiable by others reading the same data	Constructed meaning Actively generated by the researcher through sustained engagement with data
RESEARCHER ROLE	Neutral classifier Applies consistent rules; subjectivity is a source of bias to control	Interpretive mapper Uses judgement within a transparent structure; decisions are traceable	Reflexive co-constructor Subjectivity is a resource, not a threat; reflexivity is embedded in the method
CODING APPROACH	Structured & fixed Codebook established before or early in analysis; coded by multiple researchers	Shared & evolving Codebook developed collaboratively; refined as analysis proceeds	Flexible & personal Codes developed and revised by the researcher; reflects evolving interpretation
QUALITY MARKERS	Inter-rater reliability Cohen's kappa or similar; percentage agreement; structured audit trail	Transparency Detailed codebook, member checking, audit trail, reflexive memo-writing	Reflexivity & depth Reflexive journal, thick description, coherence of interpretive argument

How to read this table: Read across a row to compare how each approach handles the same question. Read down a column to build a complete picture of one approach. No approach is inherently superior — the right choice depends on your research question, design, and the epistemological tradition you are working within.

Coding Reliability TA

"How can we categorise these responses consistently?"

CR

WHEN TO USE IT

- Multi-site studies where consistency across research teams matters
- Applied or evaluation research requiring replicable categorisation
- Studies that need to demonstrate methodological rigour to stakeholders who value reliability metrics
- Large datasets where systematic, rule-based coding is practical and necessary
- Research explicitly framed within a post-positivist or quantitative-adjacent paradigm

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE IN PRACTICE

- A codebook is developed (often prior to analysis) with clear definitions and decision rules
- Two or more coders apply the codebook independently to the same data
- Inter-rater reliability is calculated (Cohen's kappa, percentage agreement)
- Discrepancies are discussed and resolved through consensus or adjudication
- Analysis reports the reliability statistics alongside thematic findings

KEY CONCEPTS

EPISTEMOLOGY
Post-positivist

THEME TYPE
Reliable category

CODER COUNT
Multiple (≥2)

CODEBOOK
Fixed / pre-defined

QUALITY MARKERS

Inter-rater reliability Cohen's kappa % agreement Audit trail Codebook fidelity

WHAT TO CITE

- Braun & Clarke (2013) *Successful qualitative research*
- Boyatzis (1998) *Transforming qualitative information*
- Hill et al. (1997) Consensual Qualitative Research

WATCH OUT FOR

Using inter-rater reliability language while conducting what is actually Reflexive TA. If your coding is evolving and personal, IRR is not appropriate — it is a quality marker for a different approach.

Codebook / Coding Frame TA

"Can we map these patterns in a way others can follow and verify?"

CF

WHEN TO USE IT

- Applied, policy, or organisational research where findings must be auditable
- Multi-researcher teams that need a shared analytic framework
- Studies where stakeholders require transparency about how categories were derived
- Research requiring comparability across datasets or time-points
- Work within a constructivist-pragmatist paradigm valuing both interpretation and accountability

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE IN PRACTICE

- A codebook is developed collaboratively and refined as analysis proceeds
- Team members code independently and compare; differences are discussed, not measured statistically
- The codebook documents code definitions, examples, and decision rules
- Member checking or peer debriefing may be used to support credibility
- Reflexive memos track how interpretive decisions were made

KEY CONCEPTS

EPISTEMOLOGY

Constructivist-pragmatist

THEME TYPE

Mapped pattern

CODER COUNT

Often multiple

CODEBOOK

Shared & evolving

QUALITY MARKERS

Detailed codebook

Audit trail

Member checking

Peer debriefing

Reflexive memos

WHAT TO CITE

- Braun & Clarke (2013) *Successful qualitative research*
- Ritchie & Spencer (1994) Framework analysis
- Gale et al. (2013) Using the framework method

WATCH OUT FOR

Describing your codebook as "fixed" when it evolved, or claiming full inductive analysis when a prior framework guided coding. Be precise about what your process actually was — reviewers notice inconsistencies.

Reflexive TA

"What meanings are these people making, and what can I say about why?"

RTA

WHEN TO USE IT

- Studies exploring how people make meaning of lived experience
- Solo or small-team research where the researcher's interpretation is central
- Work within a constructivist or interpretivist paradigm
- Research where the goal is a rich, contextual, theoretically-engaged account
- Studies where researcher positionality is acknowledged as shaping the analysis

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE IN PRACTICE

- Researcher reads data deeply and generates initial codes that reflect their engagement
- Codes are personal and evolving — not shared for reliability checking
- Themes are constructed through an iterative, non-linear process
- A reflexive journal documents interpretive moves and researcher positioning
- The final analysis tells a coherent story grounded in data and theory

KEY CONCEPTS

EPISTEMOLOGY

Constructivist-interpretivist

THEME TYPE

Constructed meaning

CODER COUNT

Typically solo

CODEBOOK

None / flexible notes

QUALITY MARKERS

Reflexive journal

Thick description

Interpretive depth

Theoretical coherence

Positionality statement

WHAT TO CITE

- Braun & Clarke (2006, 2019, 2022) foundational papers & book
- Braun & Clarke (2021) *Thematic Analysis: A Practical Guide*
- Terry et al. (2017) Thematic analysis as a reflexive methodology

WATCH OUT FOR

Claiming Reflexive TA while using inter-rater reliability or a fixed codebook — these are incompatible. Reflexive TA treats researcher subjectivity as a strength; applying reliability checks contradicts its epistemological foundations.

Signs your analytic approach needs clarification

These are not signs your study is flawed. They are signs your analytic logic needs to be made more explicit — and can usually be resolved through a clearer articulation of your choices.

MISMATCH

Using inter-rater reliability while claiming to do Reflexive TA

IRR is a quality marker for Coding Reliability TA. Reflexive TA treats researcher subjectivity as a resource — applying reliability checks directly contradicts its epistemological foundations.

MISMATCH

Calling themes "patterns of shared meaning" but treating them as topic summaries

Language from Reflexive TA with practices from Coding Reliability TA creates incoherence that reviewers and examiners will notice and question.

MISMATCH

Using a fixed codebook while describing coding as reflexive and organic

A fixed codebook is a feature of Coding Reliability or Codebook TA. Reflexive TA coding is flexible and evolving — the two approaches are not compatible in the same study.

MISMATCH

Claiming inductive analysis while applying a predefined framework

Inductive and deductive describe where codes come from, not which TA approach you are using. Clarify whether your framework was developed from the data or applied to it — and name the approach that fits.

MISMATCH

Receiving conflicting advice from supervisors or reviewers

This often means different people are assuming different TA approaches. Making your approach explicit — and articulating why it fits your study — usually resolves the confusion quickly.

MISMATCH

Feeling unsure how to justify your analytic choices in writing

If you cannot complete the coherence statement on the next page, your approach likely needs clarification — not more data or more codes. The issue is conceptual, not empirical.

A note on the word "thematic analysis" in the literature. Many published studies describe their method as "thematic analysis" without specifying which approach they used. As a result, practices from different approaches are sometimes conflated. Being explicit about which approach you are using — and why — is not pedantry. It demonstrates methodological literacy and protects the integrity of your findings.

Can you complete this sentence?

When you can write this sentence clearly and completely, your analytic approach is coherent. If you get stuck on any blank, that is useful information — it points to exactly what needs clarification before you write up your methods.

I am using type of TA to analytic aim because reason it fits my study. This means I understand themes as your definition, coding as your function for coding, and quality as your criteria.

CODING RELIABILITY TA — EXAMPLE

"I am using Coding Reliability TA to systematically categorise participant responses because consistency across coders is essential for our multi-site study. This means I understand themes as categories, coding as a structured and consistent process, and quality as inter-rater reliability."

CODEBOOK TA — EXAMPLE

"I am using Codebook TA to map patterned responses across policy contexts because the research needs to be auditable and usable by stakeholders. This means I understand themes as patterned responses, coding as a shared evolving framework, and quality as transparency and traceable decisions."

REFLEXIVE TA — EXAMPLE

"I am using Reflexive TA to interpret the meaning people make of their experiences because conceptual insight matters more than categorisation. This means I understand themes as patterns of shared meaning I generate, coding as a flexible interpretive process, and quality as reflexivity and depth."

Not sure which approach fits your study?

Use the free interactive decision tool to work through four questions and get a clear recommendation. Or book a Research Health Check with Dr Claire Moran for one-to-one guidance on your specific study.

thequalitativeresearchinstitute.com
Interactive tool · Training · Individual support